BEST PERFORMING SMALL STATES OVERALL

RANK 2022	STATE	SCORE OUT OF 2,080	RANK 2021	RANK 2020	RANK 2019	RANK 2018
1	GOA	1,341.1	2	1	1	2
2	PUDUCHERRY	1,330.1	1	2	2	1
3	SIKKIM	1,214.5	3	4	3	4
4	MIZORAM	1,146.6	4	6	5	5
5	DELHI	1,043.8	5	3	4	3
6	NAGALAND	1,020.6	7	7	7	7
7	TRIPURA	1,019.2	6	5	6	8
8	ARUNACHAL PRADESH	947.6	8	10	8	6
9	MANIPUR	944.5	9	8	10	9
10	MEGHALAYA	905.4	10	9	9	10

Meanwhile, the warm water beaches of Goa—Morjim, Calangute, Miramar, Siridao, Baina, Velsao, Colva and Palolem, Anjuna, Bagha etc.—await their Russian patrons. As the country is engaged with its neighbour Ukraine in one of its most deadly wars, the wait of the Goans is getting longer. "We had taken up the issue of allowing e-visas for UK residents with the Union government. It is done now," Sawant tells INDIA TODAY. Immediately after the Covid restrictions were eased in 2020-21, the buzz was back in Goa with a tourist inflow of 3,308,089, of which 22,128 were foreigners.

Till the tourists returned, Goa utilised the opportunity to augment its much-needed infrastructure. The latest is the new international airport at Mopa. Envisaged by Sawant's predecessor Parrikar, the airport took its name from him too. Work started in 2016 and today Goa is the only small state in India to have two international airports. In the first week of January, the first flight will take off from the airport. With less congestion charges, the new airport is also expected to ease pressure on the wallets of air travellers. According to a top official of the state, the current Dabolim airport has to be shut for four hours, so that naval aircraft can conduct their mandatory sorties.

The new airport will not only open up northern Goa for tourists but will also help facilitate and expand business activity, the official adds. Not to mention the enhanced connectivity the state will have with other cities in India and abroad. The Mopa airport will handle 4.4 million passengers in the first phase, which will gradually go up to 22 million. The old Dabolim Airport has the capacity to handle 8.5 million passengers, but doesn't have enough facilities for cargo movement. The new airport will improve the connectivity of Goa—from the existing 15 domestic and six international destinations to 35 domestic and 18 international ones. Often called the country's party capital for its exciting nightlife, natural attractions and liberal policies, Goa—according to Reserve Bank of India data—spends Rs 772 per person to create the infrastructure and facilities. Sawant hopes that with the infrastructure upgrade, Goa will be attracting rich vacationers along with backpackers. Tourism is one of the biggest employment generators for the Goans, which contributes about 17 per cent to the state's GDP. In 2021-22, the state earned Rs 7,102.9 crore from tourism activities alone.

DOMESTIC TOURISTS ARE BACK, BUT FOREIGN TOURISTS STILL ELUDE GOA'S VIBRANT BEACHES

Construction work on the eight-lane bridge on the river Zuari has picked up speed. The cable bridge connects south Goa with the state's northern part and, once commissioned, it will ease the traffic flow. The Goan authorities wanted Prime Minister Narendra Modi to inaugurate the half-ready bridge along with the Mopa airport, which apparently was denied by the officials at the Prime Minister's Office. The state, along with the National Highways Authority of India, is building expressways for smooth connectivity between its north and south. The ratio of the length of national highways and state highways to the state's total area is about 0.15 km per sq. km. However, the projects for expansion and construction of greenfield highways—Navelim to Cuncolim, Canacona outer bypass road to Polem, Sanjivani Sugar Factory, Dharbandora, to Khandepar, and Ponda to Bhoma four-laning—are in various stages of construction. Many of these development projects meet with resistance too. There are protests against many of the central government projects by several sub-regional nationalist groups such as the Manoj Parab-led Revolutionary Goans Party.

In the previous assembly polls, the party bagged around 10 per cent of the popular votes and one of the contestants, Viresh Boarkar, won the St Andre constituency defeating the BJP's Francisco Silveira. Their opposition to some central government projects had made Sawant and his ministers uneasy. Recently, they protested the